



The Algarve Coast

A coast famous for its breathtaking cliffs, golden beaches, limestone caves and rock formations, scalloped bays, and sandy islands



△ CAVE OF THE EYE

This cave is close to Benagil Beach, near Lagoa, and can be visited by boat or by swimming. The enormous “eye” in its roof is 52 ft (16 m) across.

The Algarve is the southernmost region of mainland Portugal, and its coast has two sections. The first of these, some 100 miles (160 km) long, is south-facing and extends westward from Portugal’s border with Spain out to the southwestern tip of the Iberian Peninsula, at Cape St. Vincent. The second section is west-facing and extends for 30 miles (50 km) northward from Cape St. Vincent.

Honey-colored cliffs

Bathed by the warm North Atlantic Current (an extension of the Gulf Stream), the Algarve Coast is notable for its picturesque, honey-colored limestone cliffs, small bays and coves, sheltered beaches of fine sand, and turquoise- or emerald-colored seas. Features typically formed by marine erosion can be seen along many sections. These include some large caves at the feet of cliffs, blowholes, and holes that have been excavated from headlands to create sea arches.



Parts of the shoreline are dotted with rocky sea stacks (isolated pillars of rock set off from headlands), some of which appear to be precariously balanced on the shoreline. Although limestone is a primary component of the landscape, other rocks, including sandstone and shale, are visible along scattered stretches of the coast. The region’s warm climate and strikingly beautiful scenery have made this coast a popular vacation destination.

▷ ERODED STACKS

At Praia da Rocha, near Portimao, heavily eroded limestone sea stacks embellish the shoreline. Their coloration is typical of the entire Algarve Coast.

◁ GOLD RUSH

In Roman times, gold was mined across the Algarve region. Some new gold deposits have recently been discovered, so mining may restart.

